estimated to be the largest social bloc at around 53 per cent of the population, 43.7 per cent being Hindus. Some peg their population lower, though, and since the last caste-based census dates back to 1931, there's no way to reconcile the different points of view that tend to lend a competitive edge to political bargaining.

The backwards in Maharashtra are a rainbow spectrum split up into around 353 Hindu and non-Hindu classes, including the OBCs proper (19 per cent quota), Vimukta Jati and Nomadic Tribes or VJ&NT (11 per cent) and Special Backwards (2 per cent). This diversity also hinders the creation of a larger, pan-OBC solidarity that can challenge Maratha dominance over politics. "But the census is a demand rooted in issues centred around development and economics," says Prof. Hari Narke, author and OBC activist. Scientific numbers will ensure population-based budgets for the OBCs like for the SCs and STs, and ensure welfare and schemes for education, health and employment are designed more efficiently and equitably.

Quotas may have to be revised too. OBC activists point to how it will help disrupt the status quo and, consequently, the established order in a representational democracy, where numbers matter at the hustings. "The Centre does not seem inclined to conduct a caste census. Hence, the Maharashtra government must take the initiative," says Shabbir Ahmed Ansari, president, All India Muslim OBC Organisation. A majority of Muslims are OBC and ST; elite-caste Ashraf Muslims like the Syeds form only small numbers. "The OBCs stand to make massive social and political gains with a caste census. It will help us get the deserved budgetary allocations and access to schemes," explains Ansari.

A caste census will also reveal the exact status—both demographic and socio-economic—of micro OBCs or smaller communities like the denotified tribes, who have been invisibilised by the politically and socially dominant castes, including the larger OBCs.

In March 2021, the Supreme Court had struck down Maharashtra's 27 per cent political quota for OBCs in local bodies due to a lack of empirical data about their backwardness, after which

BELAGAVI

SKIRTING BEYOND THE BORDERS

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Ajay Sukumaran



The storm over Belagavi has somewhat receded after a scrappy, acrimonious December. But local authorities in the city that's at the centre of a long-festering border dispute between Maharashtra and Karnataka haven't let down their guard. Earlier this week, they barred Maharashtra MP Dhairyasheel Mane from entering Belagavi, wary of letting things flare up again.

The move was expected. Mane, who belongs to Chief Minister Eknath Shinde's Balasahebanchi Shiv Sena (BSS) party, is the chairman of an expert panel advising the Maharashtra government on the border issue. He had been invited to a Martyr's Day programme organised on January 17 by the political outfit Maharashtra Ekikaran Samiti (MES) in which 300 people were participating.

This comes just weeks after a war of words between politicians from the two states, with the two respective legislatures approving resolutions affirming their claims over the predominantly Marathi-speaking areas on Karnataka's borders with Maharashtra. This latest chapter in the almost six-decade-old battle also has political undercurrents—election is due in BJP-ruled Karnataka this year while in Maharashtra the opposition has lost no opportunity to attack the coalition BSS-BJP government for taking a "soft stand" on the issue.

In late December, the Karnataka assembly approved a resolution stating that it will "not cede an inch of land to Maharashtra". Five days later, the Maharashtra legislature asserted that "every inch" of the 865 villages it claims along with towns like Belagavi, Karwar, Bidar, Nipani and Bhalki should be part of Maharashtra. It also said it would fight with "firm resolve and absolute strength" its almost two-decade-old case in the Supreme Court on the issue.

The latest round of the battle was sparked off after CM Shinde extended welfare measures like the freedom fighters' pension scheme to those living in the disputed border areas of Karnataka. This led to his Karnataka counterpart Basavaraj Bommai seeking the merging of Kannada-speaking parts of Maharashtra like Akkalkot and South Solapur in Solapur district and Jath in Sangli with the southern state.

As expected, there was soon an escalation of tension on the borders. Eventually, Union home minister Amit Shah summoned the two chief ministers to New Delhi and sought an end to the public spat between the two BJP-ruled